WILEY

A·M·E·R·I·C·A·N
ANTHROPOLOGICAL
ASSOCIATION

Sibling Terminology and Cross-Sex Behavior: Data from the Southeastern Nuba Mountains
Author(s): James C. Faris
Source: *American Anthropologist*, New Series, Vol. 71, No. 3 (Jun., 1969), pp. 482-488
Published by: Wiley on behalf of the American Anthropological Association
Stable URL: https://www.jstor.org/stable/670267
Accessed: 15-10-2026 06:14 UTC

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at https://about.jstor.org/terms

JSTOR

American Anthropological Association, Wiley are collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *American Anthropologist*

This content downloaded from 211.71.26.36 on Thu, 15 Oct 2026 06:14:31 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

tions in cultural anthropology: essays in honor of George Peter Murdock. W. H. Goodenough, ed. New York: McGraw-Hill. pp. 131–166.
1966 Proto-Indo-European kinship. Ethnology 5:1–36.
FRIEDL, ERNESTINE
1962 Vasilika, a village in modern Greece. New York: Holt, Rinehart and Winston.
GJERDMAN, OLOF, AND ERIK LJUNGBERG
1963 The language of the Swedish coppersmith Gypsy. Johan Dimitro Taikon, Uppsala, A-B Lundequistska.
GROPPER, RENA C.
1967 Urban nomads—the Gypsies of New York City. Transactions of the N.Y. Academy of Sciences, series II, 29:1050–1056.
HARPER, EDWARD B.
1951 Family organization of the Portland Gypsies. B.A. thesis, Reed College.
KOCHANOWSKI, JAN
1963 Gypsy studies. Part I. New Delhi: International Academy of Indian Culture.
MILLER, CAROL
1968 Mačwaya Gypsy *marimé*. M.A. thesis, University of Washington.
MITCHELL, JOSEPH
1955 Profiles—the beautiful flower. New Yorker 31:39–81.
PICKETT, DAVID WAYNE
1962 Prolegomena to the study of the Gypsies of Mexico. M.A. thesis, Syracuse University.
PITT-RIVERS, J. A.
1961 The people of the Sierra. Chicago: Phoenix Books.
SUTTLES, WAYNE
1960 Affinal ties, subsistence, and prestige among the Coast Salish. American Anthropologist 62:296–305.
YOORS, JAN
1967 The Gypsies. New York: Simon & Schuster.

SIBLING TERMINOLOGY AND CROSS-SEX BEHAVIOR: DATA FROM THE SOUTHEASTERN NUBA MOUNTAINS[1]

JAMES C. FARIS
University of Khartoum

Contrary to certain of the assumptions of Nerlove and Romney (1967) on sibling terminology and cross-sex behavior, the sibling terminology of the Southeastern Nuba manifests a primary sex-of-speaker component and is shown to be conjunctive. Other data appear to weigh against their functional hypotheses for the cross-parallel distinction in sibling terminology but support a general conclusion that there may be different levels of explanation in kinship usage and that attention should be paid to cultural conceptions of cross-sex relations.

Accepted for publication 16 October 1968

I

In a recent paper, Nerlove and Romney (1967) examine sibling terminology and cross-sex behavior from 245 societies and conclude with four general assumptions about the nature of classification systems and the implications of cross-sex distinctions in kinship usage and behavior. Data from research in progress in the southeastern Nuba Mountains of Kordofan Province, Sudan, are relevant to these assumptions, for the sibling terminology of the Kao-Nyaro-Fungor Nuba is apparently disjunctive according to the criteria of Nerlove and Romney (bearing on their first assumption); and it is arguable that sex-of-speaker occurs as a primary component in this terminology (contrary to their second assumption). Other data are relevant to their hypotheses concerning the cross-parallel distinction in sibling terminology.

A brief sketch of the southeastern Nuba —without terminology—appears in *African Systems of Kinship and Marriage* (Nadel 1950).[2] The sibling terminology is as given in Table 1.

The entire kin terminological system is precisely generational (generations based on genealogical specification) and the terms above (minus the relative age affixes, which are used only for siblings of one or both of the same parents as Ego) can be used for all persons except affines of Ego's generation that Ego refers to—or addresses—with a kinship term. The terms indicated are used in certain address contexts and frequently in everyday reference. Males and females are proficient in each other's terminology. That is, if I ask a male about the relationship between females B and D to whom he is unrelated (in Fig. 1), he will reply B is D's *waŋworen, or D is B's waŋwīa*. If I ask a female (unrelated to the parties) about the relationship between B

This content downloaded from 211.71.26.36 on Thu, 15 Oct 2026 06:14:31 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

TABLE 1. SIBLING TERMINOLOGY*

Kin type†	*Term*‡	
	Singular	*Plural*
*x*ElBr	*waŋworen*	*laŋlāloren*
*o*ElBr	*waŋworen*	*laŋlāloren*
*x*ElSi	*tutoren*	*dudādoren*
*o*ElSi	*waŋworen*	*laŋlāloren*
*x*YrBr	*waŋwīa*	*laŋalīa*
*o*YrBr	*waŋwīa*	*laŋalīa*
*x*YrSi	*tutīa*	*dudīa*
*o*YrSi	*waŋwīa*	*laŋalīa*

* Relative age affixes are included, with appropriate concord; possessive suffixes are ignored.

† *x* = male speaker; *o* = female speaker

‡ Symbols: *ŋ* = ng as in sing; *ī* and *ā* = forward vowels, as in "fly" and "ate."

and A in the figure, she will reply A is B's *waŋworen* or B is A's *tutīa*. In collective reference to mixed-sex siblings, the plural for male siblings is used by all speakers—i.e., if I ask A about the relationship between himself and B, C, and D, he will reply B. C, and D are his *laŋalīa*.

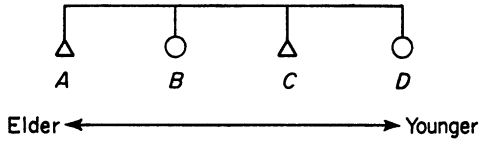


FIGURE 1

The terminology in Table 1 contains two terms of a single kin type each and two terms of three kin types each. Nerlove and Romney base their definition of disjunction operationally on the presence of indivisible numbers (or odd numbers beyond 1) of denotata (kin types) in each designatum (kin term) (1967:181). Further, they state:

> A primary component or distinction is one that partitions the entire eight kin-types into two equal subsets of four kin-types each. . . . A secondary component partitions only one of the subsets produced by a primary component. . . . A tertiary component partitions a subset containing just two kin-types that was produced by the intersection of two primary components or of a primary and a secondary component [1967:183].[3]

It is thus impossible for a system utilizing disjunctive categories (i.e., in which a term contains 3, 5, 6, or 7 of the 8 kin-types) to be divided into 2, 4, or 8 subsets along the disjunctive distinction. The Nuba terminology contains an obvious primary relational component based on relative age and also a component based on a cross-sex/parallel-sex distinction that is exclusive to male speakers. But the system, from the data presented thus far, would appear to be disjunctive, and becomes a fifth example in a universe of 246 cases, to be added to the disjunctive Hopi, Mandan, Gond, and Modoc terminologies.

I would like to suggest, however, further analysis. Anthropologists will agree with the initial assumption of Nerlove and Romney that "all natural classification systems seek conjunctive and relational categories, while they avoid disjunctive ones [1967:183]." But we may not all agree that their wide comparative point of departure allows them to focus on the "natural classification system." For the natural classification system of the Kao-Nyaro-Fungor Nuba the apparent disjunction may be resolved if we look at it in more detail, the kind of detail usually unavailable in broad comparative studies.

II

Siblings in Kao-Nyaro-Fungor (three mountainside villages that constitute the entire society) of both sexes learn terminology for same generation kinsmen shortly after they first begin speech intelligible to adults, which means they are using these terms by the age of three to four years. Sibling terms are learned second only to terms for parents and close resident kinsmen of parental generation and before children become fluent with other kin terms. I had the opportunity to watch twins—a boy and a girl—for most of the period of the first acquisition of kinship terms, and neither appeared to have any problem learning sibling terms. There was also no appreciable difference between the two in the age of acquisition. Nuba children focus on the sex of themselves and the sex of their siblings. Boys learn that female siblings are *tu*, male siblings and mixed siblings are *laŋ;* and girls learn that all siblings are *waŋ* (or *laŋ*).

This content downloaded from 211.71.26.36 on Thu, 15 Oct 2026 06:14:31 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

Children are not segregated sexually in learning these terms and may learn from several resident adults and older siblings of either sex. Learning is most commonly by listening and observation rather than by specific query or specific instruction, though mistakes are corrected. The mistakes I observed were most frequently in the application of a term to the wrong generational category, or in relative age. Mistakes, to my knowledge, were never made in either cross-sex reference or in speaker-sex. Children are nude and learn quickly physiological characteristics and many of the abundant cultural symbols specifying sex. The normal learning situation presents no difficulty to speakers, but I suggest it is because the system is not, in fact, disjunctive in meaning. Consider Table 2, which I submit represents the indigenous model.

TABLE 2. CONJUNCTIVE MODEL

Kin type	*Male speaker*	*Female speaker*
ElBr	*waŋ₂woren*	*waŋ₁woren*
YrBr	*waŋ₂wīa*	*waŋ₁wīa*
ElSi	*tutoren*	*waŋ₁woren*
YrSi	*tutīa*	*waŋ₁wīa*

It may be argued that the term *wan* (ignoring for the moment affixes and plurals) is a polysemic class with several hierarchially related meanings.[4] *Waŋ* as used by a male speaker cannot possibly have the gloss 'sibling of either sex,' for male speakers call female siblings *tu*. Yet this gloss is appropriate for one meaning of the term *waŋ* as used by female speakers. The subscripts above indicate this distinction. The denotata of the unmarked category *waŋ₁* are the four kin types ElBr, ElSi, YrBr, YrSi (female speaking), and that of the marked category *waŋ₂*, the two kin types ElBr, YrBr (male speaking). If the polysemic morpheme *waŋ* is treated as two homonyms and each homonym as a separate designatum, this analysis results in a system that is totally conjunctive and relational, with sex-of-speaker as a primary component, relative age as a primary component, and the cross-sex/parallel-sex distinction a secondary component to sex-of-speaker (on the male side). The kin type distribution is 1,1,1,1,2,2, rather than 1,1,3,3, as would initially appear to be the case.[5]

The first assumption of Nerlove and Romney is met—the apparent disjunction in the natural classification system may be resolved. The total kinship terminology supports Greenberg's universal (quoted in Nerlove and Romney 1967:181) that sex-of-speaker does not occur as a primary component in ascending generations, but the sibling terminology (according to the above analysis) is contradictory to Nerlove and Romney's extension of this to speakers within a generation, and their second assumption appears to be invalid if polysemic classes are involved in sibling terminology.

III

Although a cross-sex/parallel-sex distinction occurs as a component secondary to sex-of-speaker, and not as a primary component, some data on cross-sex relations and the postpartum sexual taboo are relevant to the possible functional explanations of Nerlove and Romney for cross-parallel sibling terminology (pp. 184–185).

The Southeastern Nuba observe a long postpartum taboo on sexual intercourse, ranging from two-and-one-half to three years, that is, until the child is weaned. This is pragmatically explained as a device to insure the well-being of the children (in a society where physical strength is of paramount importance). It is said two or three children in the same number of years puts too great a burden on a mother's milk supply. This explanation is sensible and acceptable, though a certain amount of cheating occurs, as with many social rules in all societies. For the same reason twins are unwelcome, as a series of practices surrounding their birth symbolically—as well as actually—indicates (among them, the firstborn of twins is placed under an overturned pot until after the second arrives, occasionally resulting in the death of the firstborn). The society is polygynous and a wife-sharing relationship insures that males can be sexually satisfied at all times. I can document no resentment on the part of either parent to each other or toward the child involved dur-

This content downloaded from 211.71.26.36 on Thu, 15 Oct 2026 06:14:31 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

ing the postpartum period. One would in normal circumstances expect manifestations of resentment on the part of males to be directed as much to the child as to its mother, and I am not certain I follow the logic of the association of a long post-partum sexual taboo with particularly strong emphasis on cross-sex relations. The Kao-Nyaro-Fungor Nuba simply want healthy children, and the sexual taboo appears to be acceptable to both spouses without any particular emphasis on cross-sex relations during the nursing period. Wives nursing infants do not always appreciate the fact that the sexual attention of their husbands' are directed elsewhere, but this is a concomitant of polygyny and sexual freedom as much as the postpartum sexual taboo.

Some further data are of interest: There are no male initiation rites at puberty (the society is characterized by a well-developed age-grade organization), though females on maturity undergo a series of body scarifications on both sides of the abdomen from the breasts to the hips. They also lose four lower front teeth. There are in certain patriclan sections of the society specific ceremonies attached to initial menstruation, involving isolation of the girl and flagellant rites directed toward (against?) her betrothed. Betrothal occurs after a boy reaches puberty and as much as six years before a girl is mature. During the engagement period a male labors for his future parents-in-law (or their substitutes) in bride-service. There is no bridewealth. "Marriage" is normally coterminous with pregnancy, but there is no term that can be translated 'marriage.' On pregnancy (which occurs in most cases between one to two years from initial menstruation) a girl is given a skirt such as she will wear the rest of her life, has her head shaved, ceases to cover herself with oil and ochre (the color of which was peculiar to the girl's patriclan), and after the birth of her first child, leaves her home to live with her husband. After the birth of the child and during the period of nursing—the period of the postpartum sexual taboo—the mother covers her head and shoulders with oil and ochre (the color at this time peculiar to the child's patriclan).

Marriage is very fragile and wife-stealing common (traditionally without compensation) after the postpartum period. Children of both sexes and all ages remain with their father should their mother be stolen. There is normally no shift in their residence unless circumstances such as a father's death force the situation. No illnesses or special contamination are associated with intercourse beyond the fact that excessive sexual relations are regarded as exhausting to the age grade of tribal fighters.[6]

Both males and females assume very respectful attitudes toward their spouse's parents—measured in features such as not eating from the same bowl and not sitting on the same sleeping rack. One cannot assume the latter is necessarily symbolic of sexual avoidance, however, for males regard sitting on the same sleeping rack with a father-in-law just as ill-mannered as sitting with a mother-in-law. These prohibitions are relaxed over time. The only institutionalized joking relationships to come to my attention so far are between cross-cousins of opposite sex (who are also preferred marital partners) and between either-sex offspring of males of the same matriclan. Fighting with any of these individuals, however (who are referred to by a single term), is held to result in leprosy.

Sorcery is but one of several explanations for illness, and menstrual taboos are extensive by any measure. With regard to the latter, however, it is necessary to emphasize that blood from any source and from either sex involves similar restrictions. And finally, brother-sister avoidance is absent, or at least no more marked than restrictions on all cross-sex relations. These latter are slight and, beyond exogamy and specific clanship prohibitions, are principally associated with the age and maturity of the actors. No socially mature male sits on the same sleeping rack with an immature female; no mature female sits on the same sleeping rack with a socially immature male. These restrictions apply to all cross-sex (and in some circumstances same-sex) relations, including parents and children as well as nonkinsmen, and are relaxed after maturity. It is difficult to cheat on this rule, as males and females are at all times covered with oil and various colored ochres (colors for females peculiar

This content downloaded from 211.71.26.36 on Thu, 15 Oct 2026 06:14:31 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

to patriclanship, and for males peculiar to age grades) until some years after the birth of first children, thus their sleeping racks are covered with oil and ochre. Any elder individual thereby bears public mark of his or her breach.

IV

Much of the above data would appear to argue against the specific functional hypotheses of Nerlove and Romney regarding explanations for cross-parallel sibling terminology, but this does not negate their general conclusion regarding the deeper level concern with sexual identity and cross-sex relations—a conclusion my own research strongly supports.

The Kao-Nyaro-Fungor social organization is characterized by duolineal desent and fully corporate (in all senses), named, exogamous clan sections. Matrikinsmen, except for full brothers, are normally dispersed; patrikinsmen, at least of clan sections, are normally residentially proximal. Patrigroups and matrigroups are usually functionally separate.[7] Property, both moveable and immovable, consumable and permanent, is transmitted separately in both descent lines.

Precise sexual identity is relevant in many descent-focused contexts, but it is becoming increasingly more evident that females and males are conceptual "matri-creatures" and "patri-creatures," respectively, quite apart from the fact that in a duolineal descent system each transmits membership in his (patriline) or her (matriline) group to offspring. Any individual, of course, has both matrigroup and patrigroup memberships, both of which are significant in many interaction situations. And males are, as in other societies, those most jurally responsible in both matrigroups and patrigroups. But there are a variety of deeper-level cultural symbols, conceptual associations, and considerable overt behavior that emphasize the identity of females to matrilines and of males to patrilines, with corresponding focus on sex. Although normally functionally separate, one's matrigroup in everyday situations is constantly pitted against one's patrigroup. Although some of the personnel are the same in both one's patrigroup and one's matrigroup, sentiments and affections are continually "changing sides." Matrikinsmen are the ultimate source of succor, debt responsibility, and support, yet certain types of witchcraft can be exercised (and transmitted) only in the matriline and matrikinsmen are often feared. Although one does not fear patrikinsmen and is normally in close daily interaction with them, in the final case aid must come from the matriline. In the case of extreme misbehavior, such as fighting within the patriclan section, the corrective sanction is threatened expulsion from the patriclan, not to another patrigroup or to some amorphous void, but to the matrigroup of the individual involved—"Go to your matriclan!" (*ndo ŋeŋenā?a*), it is said—threatening deprivation of a male from the very conceptual substance of his existence (a threat that can never be carried out, however, except in the rare cases where the party is the offspring of a neighboring Shilluk father, offspring whose patriline is already in question). The same threat is ineffective and has little meaning for females. Patrikinsmen stress the fact that matrikin lie in wait for the death of their uterine kinsmen so that they may inherit, ignoring the fact that property is also transmitted in the patriline and that it is to the matriline that persons of either sex must turn in times of need. There can be no threat of expulsion from the matrigroup, and fighting within the group is regarded as a severe sin.

This could produce a situation of considerable anxiety for actors, but it may be resolved by a special conceptual emphasis on one's physiological address, on one's sex, with corresponding association of males to patrilines and females to matrilines.[8] I suggest this is manifested in sibling terminology by a primary sex-of-speaker component.

Further details shall be reported after the completion of current research (Faris 1969); the point here is to call attention to a situation where a generalized psychological and structural syndrome surrounds sexual identification and cross-sex relations. The data I presented in Section III, however, indicate this is manifested in domains apart from those investigated by Nerlove and Romney.

The extent to which this is manifested in kinship terminology at the sibling level is in-

This content downloaded from 211.71.26.36 on Thu, 15 Oct 2026 06:14:31 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

dicated by a precise self-identity in relation to those toward whom one is acting. The sex-of-speaker emphasis establishes firmly the conceptual identity so relevant structurally and psychologically to the maintenance of the society. I do not know "why" females should use the same linguistic sign for all siblings as males speakers use for siblings of the same sex, but I have tried to suggest why speaker-sex is important and emphasized in the terminology.[9] Moreover, I do not know "why" the cross-sex/parallel-sex component is characteristic of male speakers only—though it corresponds with the relatively greater jural importance of males.

V

(1) The superficially-appearing disjunction in the Southeastern Nuba sibling terminology may be resolved when examined in detail. It is unfortunately on such superficial levels that most comparative studies rest. Practitioners of such research methods might take note of this example.

(2) Sex-of-speaker can occur as a primary component in sibling terminology, particularly if polysemy is involved within the terminology.

(3) Data strongly support aspects of a concluding point by Nerlove and Romney—that there may be different levels of explanation in understanding kinship usage and that particular attention should be paid to cultural conceptions of cross-sex relations (1967: 186–187). The Southeastern Nuba social organization reflects a generalized psychological syndrome in this regard (perhaps more clearly because of duolineal descent), though it is manifested largely in spheres other than those investigated by Nerlove and Romney.

NOTES

[1] Research in progress is supported by the Ford Foundation and the University of Khartoum. I should like to thank S. Nerlove and A. K. Romney for having read this paper and Ward Goodenough for valuable criticism. This does not, of course, commit them to agreement with the conclusions.

[2] For corrections to Nadel and more recent data, see Faris (1968).

[3] Nerlove and Romney err in explaining the schematic representation of their own typology, for a line through the entire figure represents *not* a secondary component, as they state (1967:183), but a primary component. A correct explanation of their typology might read: A straight line that bisects the figure into two equal parts represents a primary component; a straight line resulting in any quarter partition of the figure represents a secondary component (so long as it does not at the same time bisect the figure into two equal parts); and a straight line that results in any partitioning of the figure into eighths represents a tertiary component (so long as it does not at the same time divide the figure into either two equal parts or four equal parts).

[4] Among the other meanings relevant to specific contexts is a wife-sharing relationship between nonkinsmen or agnatic kinsmen (who are not at the same time uterine siblings). Further meanings are beyond the scope of this brief paper.

[5] W. Goodenough has pointed out to me that it is also possible (in an analysis he favors) to analyze the apparent disjunction of the set as the result of a complex discriminating component involving the simultaneous presence (or absence) of two factors: female alter and opposite sex to Ego (speaker) [*waŋ*] vs. male alter and opposite sex to Ego (speaker) [tu]. Here as well, sex-of-speaker is a primary variable. Goodenough treated Könkämä Lapp terms for the spouses of one's spouse's kin in this manner (Goodenough 1964:229).

[6] It may be pointed out that the Southeastern Nuba believe repeated intercourse is necessary to produce children and a child may "biologically" have several fathers. Though a child's blood comes wholly from its mother, its flesh and other substance comes from its father(s). The fact that a child's hands, arms, facial features, body size, etc., may come from different men does not alter legal rights over the child in the slightest nor affect clan membership.

[7] Functional "overlap" of matrigroups and patrigroups is a complex situation and is the subject of a paper dealing with certain cultural and symbolic aspects of systems whose social organization is characterized by duolineal descent and clanship (as opposed to the sociofunctional considerations that have heretofore been the subject of research—cf. Forde 1950; Goody 1961; Harris 1962; Leach 1963); see Faris 1969.

[8] This does not always resolve the situation obtaining between duolineal kinsmen of the same sex, however (such as full brothers). These interpersonal relationships are especially marked in the society by ambiguity and tension.

[9] The same sign conservatism characterizes the entire kin terminological system (a variant

This content downloaded from 211.71.26.36 on Thu, 15 Oct 2026 06:14:31 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms

Hawaiian) and indeed the entire language. The terminology contains very few terms, most of which are polysemic. Why some cultures prefer polysemic classes whereas other cultures utilize separate signs is a problem with many implications for further research.

REFERENCES CITED

FARIS, J.
1968 Some aspects of clanship and descent in the Southeastern Nuba Mountains of Kordofan Province, Sudan. Sudan Notes and Records 49:45–57.
1969 Some cultural considerations of duolineal descent organization. Ethnology 8(3).

FORDE, D.
1950 Double descent among the Yakö. *In* African systems of kinship and marriage. A. R. Radcliffe-Brown and D. Forde, eds. London: Oxford University Press. pp. 285–332.

GOODENOUGH, W.
1964 Componential analysis of Könkämä Lapp kinship terminology. *In* Explorations in cultural anthropology. W. Goodenough, ed. New York: McGraw-Hill. pp. 221–238.

GOODY, J.
1961 The classification of double descent systems. Current Anthropology 2:3–25.

HARRIS, R.
1962 The political significance of double unilineal descent. Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute 92:86–101.

LEACH, E.
1963 Some unconsidered aspects of double descent. Man 62:214.

NADEL, S. F.
1950 Dual descent in the Nuba hills. *In* African systems of kinship and marriage. A. R. Radcliffe-Brown and D. Forde, eds. London: Oxford University Press. pp. 333–359.

NERLOVE, S., AND A. K. ROMNEY
1967 Sibling terminology and cross-sex behavior. American Anthropologist 69:179–187.

CONCEPTS OF TIME AMONG THE AINU OF THE NORTHWEST COAST OF SAKHALIN[1]

EMIKO OHNUKI-TIERNEY
University of Wisconsin

Presented here is the basic cognitive structure underlying concepts of time among the Ainu of the northwest coast of southern Sakhalin, now resettled in Hokkaido. The temporal structure is examined by analyzing the Ainu units of what we call time and the cultural meaning attached to each unit. The Ainu time consists of a series of units in binary opposition. However, this opposition is not absolute but is relative to context. This temporal structure illustrates the dyadic structure of the Ainu world view, which has been the prime object of the author's study of the Ainu culture.

Accepted for publication 21 November 1968

I

My object here is to present the cognitive structure that seems to underly the conception of time among the Ainu of the northwest coast of Sakhalin. My discussion is based primarily on information I gathered in 1965–66 from *Husko,*[2] a gifted Sakhalin Ainu woman who is now sixty-eight years of age. I consider the use of one informant for a study of cognitive structure to be methodologically sound because it allows the scholar to study in depth the whole cognitive structure of a single culture carrier. A study based on many informants, on the other hand, has to be reduced to the common denominator, because the cognitive structure of every culture carrier differs to some extent from those of his fellow men.

In what follows, I shall use the term "Ainu" to mean those Ainu who, in the recent past, inhabited the northwest coast of southern Sakhalin, north of *Rayčiska* (Japanese designation: Raichishika) to the former Russo-Japanese border.

II

The Ainu universe, called *mosiri,* is the total sphere of mental and physical activities and phenomena. The *aynu* (humans), living and dead, their deities (*kamuy*), and their demons (*oyasi*) have occupied it since time immemorial. It comprises southern Sakhalin, the adjacent sea, and the sky above. The Ainu conceive the universe spatially as well as temporally as analogous to a human body. Thus it has a head and posterior, and a limited life span.

The largest temporal unit of the Ainu, then, is the life span of the universe. The

This content downloaded from 211.71.26.36 on Thu, 15 Oct 2026 06:14:31 UTC
All use subject to https://about.jstor.org/terms